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State Legislature: Democrat trails in bid to reclaim state Senate seat

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A Los Angeles-area lawmaker running for the state Senate seat he was forced out of because of a sexual harassment scandal was trailing three challengers in early returns Tuesday night.

It was one of four closely watched election results that will determine whether Democrats in the Legislature will regain their two-thirds supermajority.

Former Sen. Tony Mendoza, D-Artesia (Los Angeles County), had 12 percent among a field of 11 candidates. The top challengers were Republican business owner Rita Topalian at 28 percent and Democratic Montebello Mayor Vanessa Delgado at 15 percent.

If no candidate receives a majority, the top two will face off Aug. 7.

Mendoza resigned in February after a Senate investigation found he "more likely than not" engaged in unwanted sexual advances toward six women. He then ran for the office in both the special election to fill the seat and the primary to determine who will move on to the November ballot for the next four-year term.

In the top-two primary election, Topalian (28 percent) and Democrat Pico Rivera City Councilman Bob Archuleta (17 percent) were leading. Mendoza had 8 percent.

Other key races Tuesday:

Recall: A Republican-led effort to recall Sen. Josh Newman, D-Fullerton (Orange County), was failing, 62 percent to 38 percent in early returns. Senate Democrats need to hold both this seat and Mendoza's seat for a chance at regaining their supermajority, which enables them to raise taxes and put constitutional amendments on the ballot without GOP help.

Newman faced a recall over his vote to increase gas taxes and vehicle registration fees last year.

Assembly contests: Democrats needed to win one of two special elections to regain their supermajority, which they lost last year when two Southern California members resigned amid sexual misconduct allegations: Assemblymen Matt Dababneh and Raul Bocanegra.

Primary elections for those seats were held in April, setting the stage for Tuesday's runoffs.

Top contenders included Democrat Luz Rivas facing Republican Ricardo Benitez for the seat once held by Bocanegra, and Democrat Jesse Gabriel facing Republican Justin Clark for Dababneh's vacancy. Results were pending.

Bay Area: In the Democrat-laden race to succeed Assemblyman Tony Thurmond, D-Richmond, who ran for state schools chief, Buffy Wicks jumped out front with 34 percent of the vote. Dan Kalb was in second-place with 16 percent in the top-two primary, with 8 percent of precincts counted.

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